

By Ambreesh Mishra

For close to six months now, Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan has spoken so eloquently about stamping out corruption that even his close aides had begun to fear a backlash. Those apprehensions have now come true in unexpected ways.

Chouhan is now in the eye of a storm over an alleged Rs 100-crore land scam in the state's business and industrial hub Indore. At the core of the allegations is his Commerce and Industry Minister Kailash Vijayvargiya, regarded as Chouhan's second-in-command. Ever since an anti-corruption court in Indore on April 6 ordered the Lokayukta to register a case and probe the allegations, a rattled BJP has watched the drama from the sidelines. The petitioner, ex-minister and Congress leader Suresh Seth who lost the mayoral election to Vijayvargiya in 1999, has accused Chouhan's trouble-shooter of clearing the sale of a plot of land owned by the Indore Municipal Corporation (IMC) while he was mayor in 2004.

The IMC had leased out the three-acre plot in downtown Indore to Dhanalaxmi Chemicals for 30 years in 1980. Seth alleges that Vijayvargiya had presided over the sale of lease to Nanda Nagar Credit Cooperative Society headed by his lieutenant and MLA Ramesh Mendola for Rs 1.28 crore while the prevailing market price was more than Rs 65 crore. Mendola was a member of the mayor-in-council of the IMC. Seth alleges that since the industry was a mere tenant, it had no right to sell the lease, nor was the IMC empowered to sanction it.

Vijayvargiya defends himself saying that the low price was agreed upon since the cooperative had proposed to open a charitable school for poor children. The IMC had sent the proposal to the Government with which it is still pending. The industry had already built a multi-storied residential complex on the land. The court has asked the anti-corruption ombudsman to file its report in 90 days.

Chouhan stands at a crossroad as

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The Plot THICKENS

The going gets tough for Chouhan and his strongman Vijayvargiya as a six-year-old land scam resurfaces

the Urban Administration Minister and former chief minister Babulal Gaur has reportedly turned down the IMC's proposal and sent the file to the chief minister. The relationship between Vijayvargiya and Chouhan has often foxed political pundits—the former is the main contender for the chief minister's post should Chouhan's fortunes nosedive.

Vijayvargiya's troubles couldn't

have come at a worse time. The powerful minister who controls the cash-rich business-builder lobby of Indore was being tipped for a major department as well as the state BJP chief's post in an expected reshuffle. Vijayvargiya also has a ruthless streak and has not shied away from trampling on the toes of such formidable leaders as former Union minister Sumitra Mahajan in his bid to